

DONWELLS CUE

Operator's Manual

Preparation, playback, recovery, and live-show operations

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A practical handbook for the person preparing and running audio cues in a live show. Includes same-machine video output, remote control, recovery procedures, and printable checklists.

This edition describes the current source, including the `.dwcue` / `.dwcuepack` naming changes. It is not a claim that every downloaded installer or platform combination has been individually certified; check the release notes and rehearse on the actual machine and build you will use. Screenshots remain from an earlier isolated example show in the Electron application using locally built production renderer assets; the practice media is silent.

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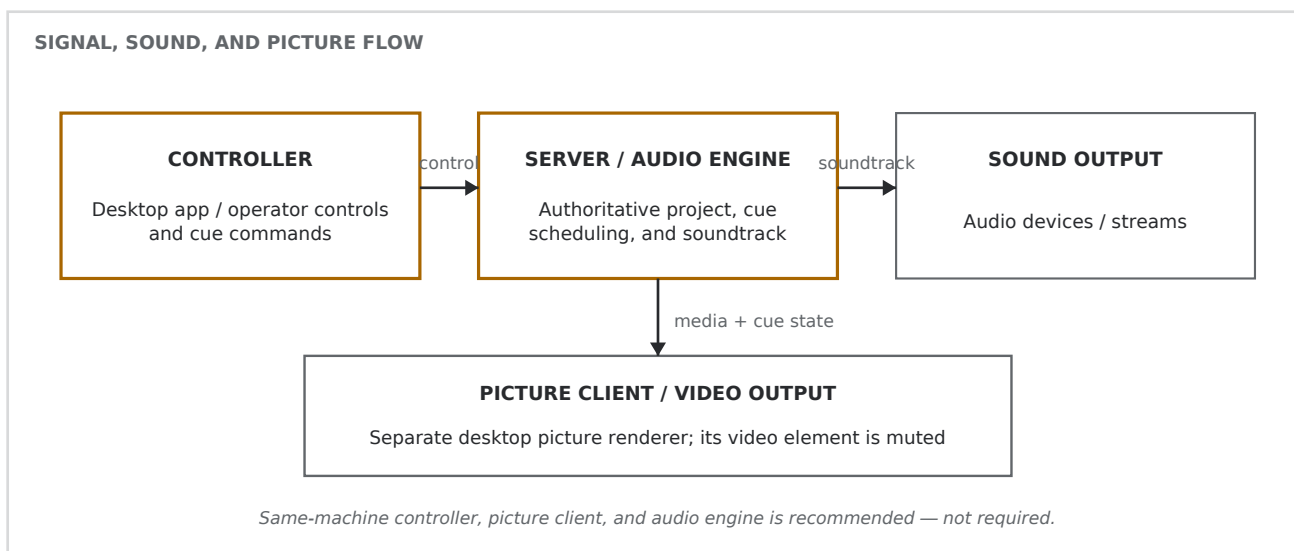
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1. Read this before the show

What DonWells Cue does

DonWells Cue plays prepared audio cues for theatre, conferences, live events, and installations. A playlist holds the planned sequence. One Shots provide independent quick-play copies for stings and effects. You can prepare trims, fades, loops, and transitions, then use Show Mode for performance.

The desktop app is the controller. A separate audio engine reads the media, runs the cues, and drives the sound device. In normal local operation both run on the same computer. In a network setup the engine runs on the computer connected to the sound system. The sound does not come from the remote controller's browser or speakers merely because it displays the meters.



The Video Output window is a separate picture renderer on the desktop computer. Its video element is muted; the audio engine remains the source of the soundtrack. A same-machine arrangement is recommended; chapter 9 explains where the picture appears when the audio engine is remote.

The four operating rules

1. **Confirm the next target before GO.** Read the cue name beside **Play Next** and look for the **Up Next** marker. Selection, an armed target, and a playing cue are different states.
2. **Rehearse what happens at the end.** Imported cues can have **Play Next** end behavior and **Stop All Other Cues** ducking. Do not assume every new cue stops and waits, or that firing a sting leaves a bed running.
3. **Treat Preview as a real output.** Choose a separate headphone or monitor output. Sending Preview to the same physical speakers as Main makes it audible to the audience even though its device ownership is safely shared.
4. **Preserve a known-good show.** Save a rehearsal copy, keep the media with it, and test the exported copy before travel. Autosave is not a versioned backup.

SAFETY NOTE

CAUTION — Stop is not necessarily instant. The **Stop All Cues** button and the default **Escape** shortcut use the project's Stop All fade. The default is 1 second; 0 means immediate. Rehearse the configured behavior and know the venue's independent console mute or other emergency-silence procedure.

Language and terminology

This manual uses the English labels. Change language through **Settings -> User Interface -> Language** or the desktop **View -> Language** menu. That preference belongs to the device, not to the show. The app includes 21 languages and right-to-left layouts for Arabic, Persian, and Urdu.

Term	Meaning in this manual
Show / project	The cue document saved natively as a <code>.dwcue</code> file, together with its media and related assets.
Cue	An audio item, including an item whose media also contains video.
Selected	The item you are inspecting or editing; selection alone is not a play command.
Up Next	The displayed target for the next GO, chosen automatically or by an explicit Set As Next override.
GO	The Play Next action; Space is its default shortcut.
One Shot	An independent quick-play copy in the One Shots bank.
Engine / server	The process that owns audio playback and the active project.
Portable archive	A ZIP-based <code>.dwcuepack</code> export containing one active show and the files in its dedicated project folder.
Legacy import	A <code>.liveplay</code> show or <code>.lpa</code> archive converted one way into a new canonical <code>.dwcue</code> without changing the original source bytes.

2. First setup and a safe first cue

Install and prepare the computer

Get the installer for your operating system and architecture from the [official releases page](#). Check its release notes against this manual's source edition. Do not update the app, operating system, audio driver, or show files immediately before a performance without rehearsal.

Connect the audio interface before opening the show. Confirm the correct outputs at the sound console, start with a conservative listening level, connect mains power, and disable sleep for the performance using the operating system's controls. Prevent notification sounds from reaching the audience. Keep a separate copy of the show and its media on reliable storage.

On launch, the desktop normally starts its managed local server automatically. The welcome screen indicates **Using local server on this computer** once connected. If the engine is starting, wait for connection rather than repeatedly reopening the app. The **Connect to a server on the network...** option reveals remote setup; see chapter 10 before using it.

Create a show

1. On the welcome screen choose **New Show**.
2. Enter a descriptive **Show name**, such as `Evening Show - rehearsal`.
3. Beside **Location**, choose **Choose...**. Location is a read-only summary, not a text field.
4. In the folder picker, navigate to the destination. You may type an absolute path in its path bar and press Enter. Choose **Select folder**.
5. Back in the combined name/location form, check both values and choose **Create Show**.

DonWells Cue creates `<show name>.dwcue` and `media/` in the selected folder; portable exports use `.dwcuepack`. Keep that folder dedicated to the show. A remote picker uses the engine computer. See chapter 11 for legacy import and non-overwrite safeguards.

Make the first cue deliberately manual

1. Choose **Import Media**, then **Choose files...**, and select a short, familiar audio file.
2. Wait for import and audio readiness; a listed file may not yet be decoder-ready.
3. Open the cue's **Edit** control. In **Basic Info**, set **End Behavior** to **Nothing** for this first exercise. Review **Ducking** before playing other cues alongside it.
4. Open **Settings** and select the intended **Audio Device**. Check the device name at the main output strip. Use the cue's **Output** tab only if it needs a specific output override.
5. Close the properties panel. Check the name beside **Play Next**. If it is not the intended cue, use that row's **Set As Next** control and confirm the displayed target.
6. With the sound system at a safe level, choose **Play Next** once. Confirm the correct active cue, moving time, meters, and actual sound at the intended output.
7. Choose **Stop All Cues**. Observe its fade and verify that all active cues stop.
8. Save through **File**. Reopen during rehearsal and recheck media and device selection.

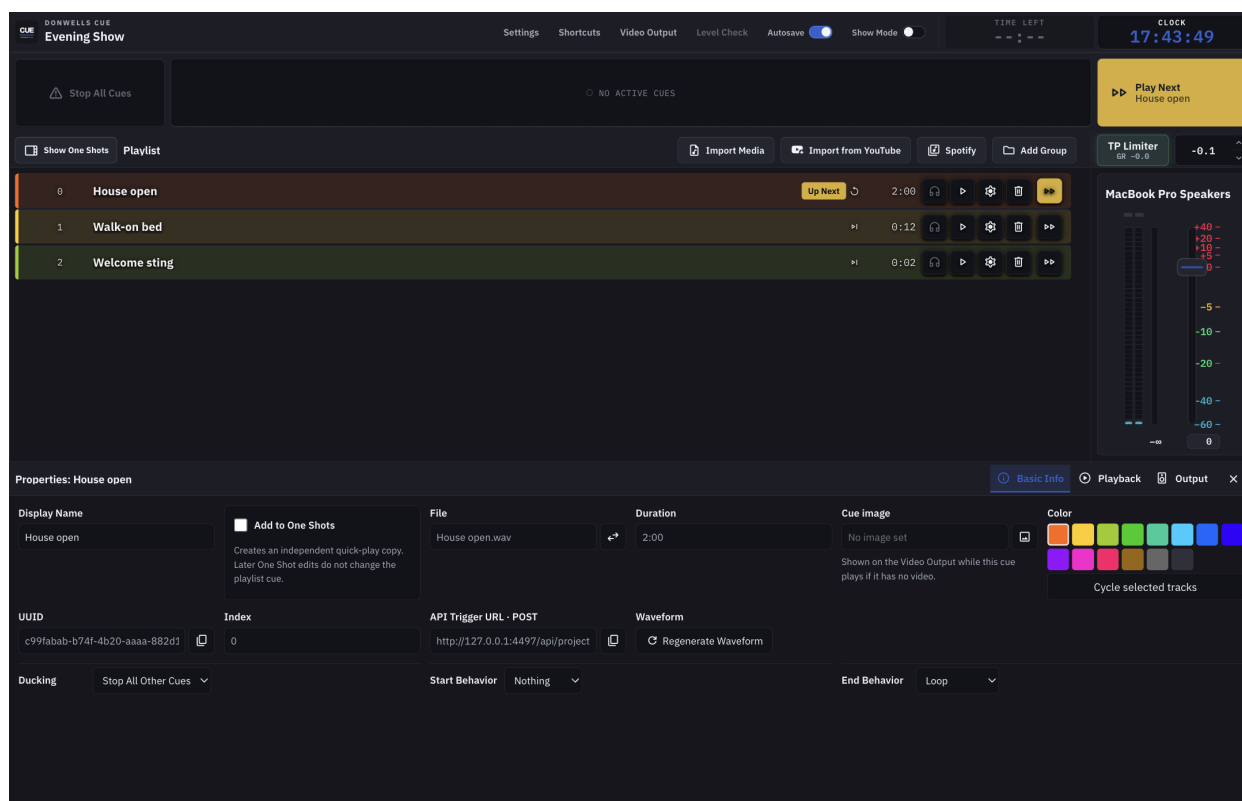
SAFETY NOTE

CHECK — Meters are not the whole signal path. A moving playhead proves transport; a meter proves a signal at that meter. Neither proves the console input, amplifier, loudspeaker, or headphone destination is correct. Listen at the actual destination.

3. Find your way around the workspace

Edit Mode

Use Edit Mode to import, organize, and configure the show. The top bar contains project settings, shortcuts, video output, level checking, Autosave, and the Show Mode switch. Transport sits below it: **Stop All Cues**, the active-cue area, and **Play Next** with its target name. The playlist contains the prepared cue order. The output strip shows the selected device, main level, meters, and true-peak limiter.



Edit workspace with House open armed as Up Next and its Basic Info properties open. Example media is silent.

The cue row provides **Set As Next**, **Preview**, **Play**, **Edit**, and **Delete** controls in Edit Mode. Hover for the current tooltip rather than relying on icon shape alone. **Play** fires a cue directly; **Set As Next** toggles its manual GO override without playing it. The **Edit** control opens **Properties**, with **Basic Info**, **Playback**, and **Output** tabs.

An empty One Shots bank is collapsed by default. Choose **Show One Shots** to reveal it. Assigning a cell can reveal the bank automatically unless you have explicitly chosen its visibility. Collapsing it is a layout decision, not a stop or disarm command.

Show Mode

Switch to **Show Mode** for performance after preparation is complete. It simplifies the interface and emphasizes transport and large cue controls. It is not an audio lockout: GO, cue triggering, and assigned control inputs remain live. One Shots require arming in Show Mode. Returning to Edit Mode disarms those cells.

Rehearse at the actual display size and app zoom. Keep the next cue name and active-cue controls visible. If a panel or dialog obscures transport, close it before the next call. The **Shortcuts** display is useful during training; check **Customize Shortcuts...** when taking over somebody else's show.

Selection is not arming

Arrow keys can move selection without starting sound. The selected item's properties may be visible while a different item is Up Next. Use **Set As Next** when you need an explicit GO target. Pressing it again on the manually armed row clears that override; an automatic candidate can remain. Always read the target shown on **Play Next** rather than repeatedly clicking to make sure a cue is armed.

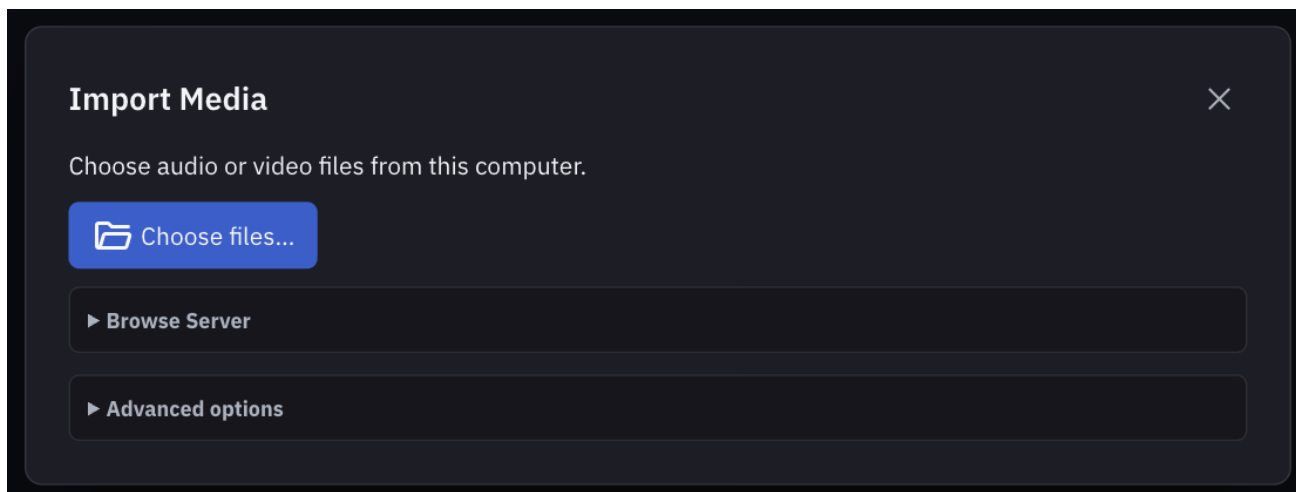
Automatic Up Next is enabled by default. Opening a project prepares the first playable item; when a cue with **End Behavior: Nothing** stops, the next sibling is prepared. A natural end at the end of the top-level list can wrap to the first playable item. This prepares a later GO; it does not itself start the next cue. An explicit override takes precedence. Selection alone is not arming.

An accepted GO consumes an explicit override. A rejected command retains it for retry. If the cue fails to start, inspect readiness and the connection before pressing again. Repeated input while the same action is awaiting acknowledgment is suppressed, but a new press after the first action completes is a new command.

4. Import and protect the media

Local files first

Open **Import Media**. In local mode the primary action is **Choose files.... Browse Server** and **Advanced options** are collapsed until needed. The server browser remains useful when media is already on the engine computer, including a same-machine setup.



The local Import Media dialog keeps file selection primary and exposes server browsing and advanced options only when needed.

In **Browse Server**, double-click folders to open them. Click files to select; use Shift or Ctrl/Cmd-click for multiple files, then **Import selected**. The file list distinguishes recognizable media, unsupported file types, and files whose type still needs verification. An extension or icon is not proof of decodability; wait for the import result.

Remote operation separates the two computers: **From This Computer** transfers files from the controller, while **Browse Server** selects files already accessible to the engine. Do not enter a controller-only path into the server browser and expect it to exist remotely.

Copy or link deliberately

The import dialog starts with **Copy into project media** and **Reuse existing copy** when opened. Check the choices under **Advanced options** if your workflow needs something else.

Choice	Operational consequence
Copy into project media	The show has a local media copy in its <code>media/</code> folder. Saved paths for copied media are relative to the show folder, making the folder easier to move as a unit.
Link in place	The show continues to depend on the original absolute server path. Keep that file and volume available; renaming, moving, unmounting, or losing the source breaks the dependency.
Reuse existing copy	Reuse an identical existing file in project media instead of creating another copy. Matching is based on file content, not just its name.
Skip it	Omit an import whose content matches an existing project-media file.
Keep another copy	Import another copy using a unique filename rather than overwriting the existing file.

For a travelling show, prefer copying media and test the export on the destination machine. A `.dwcue` file alone is not an audio package. Do not assume an archive has collected every externally linked file; verify the imported result with the original sources unavailable.

Import processing and readiness

Project/import settings include automatic loudness matching, true-peak reduction, and silence trimming. The new-project defaults in this source enable true-peak reduction, while loudness matching and silence trimming are off. Review the active project's settings rather than assuming another operator left the defaults unchanged.

Processing can change the resulting media or its playback level. Keep the original files outside the working copy if you may need to undo preparation decisions. Listen to entrances, tails, and intentional silence after trimming or processing. Check that music, dialogue, and effects have sensible relative levels; matching a numeric loudness target does not make every cue equally appropriate for the room.

Do not start the show while media is still being verified or decoded. Resolve failed or missing files, then audition the cue. Regenerating a waveform updates its display; it is not a substitute for a successful decoder load or a listening check.

Online imports

YouTube and Spotify import controls are available in Edit Mode. They depend on external services and downloader availability. Prepare and verify these imports before the show, not on a live cue call. Use only material you are authorized to obtain and perform; an import feature does not supply a public-performance licence. Once imported, rehearse from the local show media rather than relying on a working internet connection at the venue.

5. Build cues and transitions

Name, inspect, and arrange

Use descriptive **Display Name** values that match the show caller's language. Color can group related material, but do not make color the only cue identifier. The internal **UUID** identifies the cue; **Index** reflects its place in the current hierarchy and can change when you reorder. When assigning a **Go to Index** target, use the index shown by the app, not a printed cue number from another system.

Drag cues into the required order and use **Add Group** where a folder-like structure makes the show easier to navigate. Save and rehearse after rearranging any sequence with jumps, groups, or automatic transitions. A correct-looking playlist does not prove that every transition points where you intend.

Replacing a cue's file keeps its cue identity but reloads the corresponding media decoder. Recheck duration, trims, fades, waveform, level, and end behavior after replacement; an old trim can be inappropriate for the new file. Do media replacements during preparation, not during a live cue.

Trims, fades, and normalization

Open **Properties -> Playback** for the waveform and timing controls. Set **In Point** and **Out Point** around the part you want to use. Listen to the entrance and exit; a visually quiet waveform may contain room tone, a breath, or an intentional pause. Leave enough material for any fade or transition you configure.

Control or concept	Use it for
In Point / Out Point	Choosing the playback region without treating a waveform view as a destructive audio editor.
Play Fade In	The cue's fade-in at the start of playback.
Stop Fade Out	The authored fade at the end of the cue's playback region; it also contributes to manual-stop timing.
Cross-fade	Starting the following cue before the current cue ends, for overlap. Rehearse with both cues' ducking and fades.
Start Next at Marker	Starting the next cue at a chosen waveform marker instead of relying on the ordinary end point.
Fade Out at Marker	Fading the current cue as the Start Next marker transition occurs.

Start Next at Marker takes precedence over ordinary cross-fade timing. Loop suppresses automatic next, Start Next, and cross-fade until its live behavior is changed. Manual Stop uses the greater of Stop Fade Out and the cue's legacy fade-out duration, which is 1 second on a new cue even when the visible Stop Fade Out is 0. Fade Out at Marker uses that legacy duration. Stop All uses its separate global fade. Rehearse these paths separately rather than assuming a zero visible fade makes every stop instantaneous.

The waveform's **Normalize** control offers **Loudness (LUFS)** and **True peak (dBTP)**. It writes an absolute cue **Volume** value, not a rewritten media file, and can set Volume as high as +10 dB. The true-peak target cannot exceed the active limiter ceiling. After normalizing, inspect Volume and audition at a safe output level; normalization can make a cue substantially louder.

Choose the end behavior deliberately

Properties -> Basic Info -> End Behavior is the main supported way to control what follows a cue.

End Behavior	Result to rehearse
Nothing	End the cue without automatically starting a following item. Use for manually called, stop-and-wait cues.
Play Next	Start the next sibling in the same immediate playlist or group container.
Go to Item	Start the specifically selected cue when this cue ends.
Go to Index	Start the item at the configured index; recheck after changing the hierarchy.
Loop	Repeat the cue's playback region until the operator changes the live course of playback.

Do not use a loop as a substitute for rehearsing the loop boundary. Check for clicks, a level change, or a gap at the join on the actual output hardware. See chapter 7 for **Cue to Continue**, which releases the current pass without rewriting the saved Loop setting.

SAFETY NOTE

CURRENT LIMIT — Audio Start Behavior. The Basic Info **Start Behavior** dropdown exposes Play Next / Play Item / Play Index choices that are not executed by the current server path. Do not build a live sequence around those choices. Use the supported End Behavior controls or **Start Next at Marker**, and rehearse the result. This limitation is separate from a group's implemented Play First / Play All behavior.

Groups

A group's **Start Behavior** can be **Play First** or **Play All**. Play First triggers its first child; Play All can start several children together. For Play All, set each child's ducking so the children do not immediately stop one another when simultaneous playback is intended.

A group's GO succeeds when the requested first child starts, or when at least one child of a Play All group starts. If no child can start, the group stays armed. Check the actual active cues after a partially successful group start; an accepted group command does not guarantee that every child decoded successfully.

A child's **Play Next** stays inside its immediate group. The last child does not automatically climb to the next top-level item. To leave a group, configure the final child with an explicit **Go to Item** or **Go to Index** destination.

SAFETY NOTE

CURRENT LIMIT — Group endings. A group's own End Behavior is displayed in Properties but is not consumed by the current server sequencer. Put the required exit action on a child cue. Do not rely on the group's displayed ending to run the next scene.

Beds, stings, and ducking

The **Ducking** choices are **Stop All Other Cues**, **No Ducking**, and **Duck Others**, with a **Duck Level**. Decide what a cue should do to sound that is already running before you fire it.

- For a sting that must leave a music bed running unchanged, choose **No Ducking** and rehearse both levels together.
- **Duck Others** temporarily sets each other active cue's gain to the absolute Duck Level, then restores its prior gain. It is not a relative reduction: a cue already quieter than that target can become louder. Choose and rehearse the target against every cue that may be running, including the restoration when ducking ends.
- **Stop All Other Cues** is intentionally disruptive. It is appropriate when replacing existing playback, not when adding a layer that must coexist.

6. Audio outputs, Preview, levels, and timecode

Establish the main output

Open **Settings** and choose **Audio Device** for the show. Check the device name in the main output strip and listen at the sound system. Hardware names and availability can change when a device is unplugged, a driver changes, or the show moves to another computer.

A cue may specify a different **Properties -> Output -> Output device**. An explicit cue override can explain why one cue is silent on the expected Main output while other cues work. Audit overrides when preparing the backup machine, rather than assuming the project's main selection overrides every cue.

The engine supports more advanced routing through its API, but the current desktop app does not mount the routing-matrix panel. This manual's supported operator path is the project device selections and per-cue Output settings; do not look for a working matrix editor in the current app.

Configure Preview before using headphones

1. Connect and identify the intended headphone or monitor device.
2. Open **Settings -> Preview Device** and select it.
3. At a safe level, use a cue's **Preview** control and verify that it is heard only where intended.
4. Stop the preview before returning to show operation.

If Preview is not configured, its cue-row control opens Project Settings rather than silently choosing a destination. Preview is separate from the live cue transport and does not drive Video Output. Changing the Preview device no longer closes a hardware device still owned by Main, but sharing a physical output still makes both signals audible there.

SAFETY NOTE

CAUTION — No automatic audience isolation. The word Preview does not make the output private. Use an actually separate device/output and test it with the console operator. Do not audition an unknown cue through Main during a performance.

Gain, metering, and the limiter

Balance cues at their own level controls first, then use the main output level for the overall show. Leave practical headroom for overlapping cues. A large positive gain setting can make a quiet source unexpectedly loud; changing the output target is not a replacement for a listening check.

The selected output target influences meter presentation, loudness targets, and limiter ceiling. The Live target uses a true-peak ceiling of approximately **−0.1 dBTP** by default. The **TP Limiter** control shows gain reduction; the ceiling can be adjusted. Keep the limiter enabled unless you have a specific, rehearsed reason not to.

A limiter reduces digital peaks; it does not protect against an inappropriate acoustic level, a badly balanced cue, a wrong output patch, or downstream console gain. Persistent large gain reduction is a reason to lower and rebalance the source, not to raise the ceiling until the warning disappears. Use **Level Check** during preparation and resolve problems before switching to Show Mode.

Output LTC timecode

LTC is an audio-encoded synchronization signal for other equipment. It can be loud and unpleasant if routed to audience speakers. Set **Settings -> LTC Device**, then enable **Properties -> Output -> Output LTC Timecode** only on cues that require it. Select the frame rate and start timecode to match the receiving system.

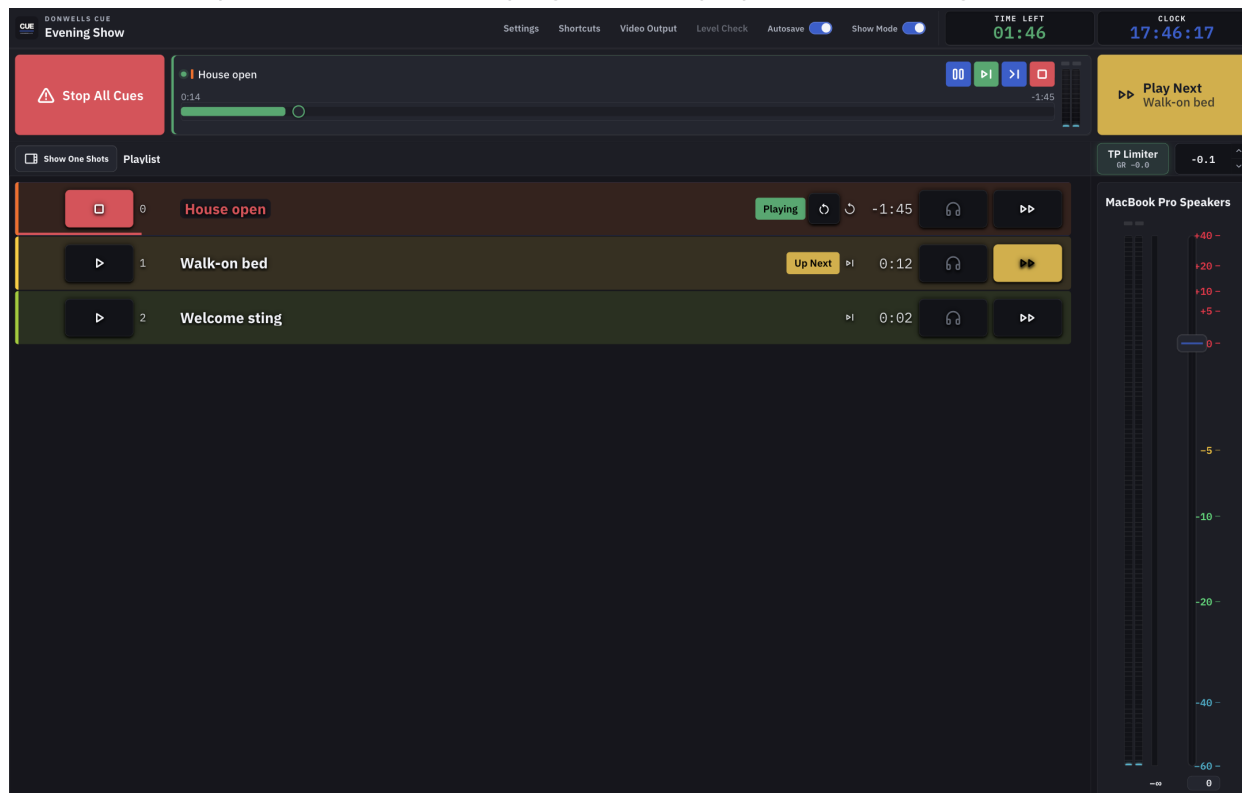
The engine supports 24, 25, 29.97 non-drop, 29.97 drop-frame, and 30 frames per second. The receiving device must use the same convention; drop-frame and non-drop are not interchangeable labels. Confirm lock and the starting timecode with the receiving operator during rehearsal, including what happens on stop, seek, replay, and a loop.

Keep the LTC destination separate from the audience audio path. Do not enable timecode on a cue merely because the checkbox is available. Record the device assignment and frame rate on the show handover sheet.

7. Run the show

A repeatable GO procedure

1. Confirm the correct show and a connected, ready engine.
2. Read the caller's cue and find the intended item.
3. Read the name beside **Play Next** and check **Up Next** in the list. Use **Set As Next** if you need to override the automatic candidate; do not toggle an already correct manual target off.
4. On the cue call, press **Play Next** or its assigned shortcut once.
5. Confirm the expected active cue and progress, then prepare the next target.



Show Mode with House open playing and Walk-on bed armed as the next GO target. The visible meters remain quiet because the example media is silent.

The default GO key is **Space**. **Enter** is Play Selected, a separate action. Check the project's shortcut assignments before operating; do not transfer keyboard habits from another show without checking them. Controls are not acknowledged merely because you clicked: if a cue remains armed and does not start, check readiness and connection before retrying.

Active-cue controls

The active-cue area provides per-cue controls as appropriate. Pause/Resume holds and resumes playback. Stop ends the cue with its configured stop behavior. A row's live controls can also stop or restart that cue. Restarting is a fresh playback instance, not a continuation of a previously armed one-pass action.

Stop All Cues affects all current live cues, not just the selected row. It is available by button and by the assigned shortcut. With the default project settings the fade is 1 second. Set and rehearse a 0-second Stop All fade only if immediate silence is the required operating policy.

Finish a loop without changing the saved show

Use **Cue to Continue** on an active looping cue when the current loop pass should finish and then advance. The cue must be authored to Loop. The action belongs to this playback instance: it disables repeating for this pass and resolves the continuation from a saved item/index destination or the next sibling. If no valid target exists, the current pass finishes without starting another cue. The saved End Behavior remains Loop.

Stopping, replaying, removing the cue, replacing its media, using Stop All, or switching projects cancels that one-pass continuation. A later replay uses the authored behavior again. By contrast, the separately assignable keyboard/MIDI **Toggle Loop** action sets **End Behavior** to **Loop** when it was not Loop, otherwise to **Nothing**; it does not restore the previous ending. This is a project edit, autosaved while Autosave is enabled and otherwise left dirty until you save. Use Cue to Continue when you intend only a one-pass release without changing the authored show.

Jump Cue stops the current cue and advances immediately rather than waiting for the loop end. Rehearse the exact jump target and audible transition before using it live. Neither Cue to Continue nor Jump Cue has a default keyboard binding; use its visible active-cue control or assign a deliberate shortcut.

When the expected cue does not start

A failed GO preserves the armed target. It may be waiting for media, unable to decode, disconnected, or pointing at an unavailable item. Read the state and resolve the cause. Do not assume that selecting a different row has changed the armed target; use Set As Next and confirm the displayed name.

For group playback, verify which children actually started. For overlapping playback, verify the new cue's Ducking mode. If the wrong material is audible, follow the rehearsed stop or console-mute procedure first, then investigate without repeatedly firing additional cues.

At the interval and at the end

Stop or intentionally leave only the required interval material running. Disarm unnecessary One Shots, verify the next target for the restart, and avoid editing device assignments while audio is live. After the final cue, confirm that all active cues and previews have stopped. Save any intended changes, make the required backup, and choose the appropriate client/server quit action in chapter 11.

8. One Shots, keyboard control, and MIDI

Prepare independent quick-play cues

Reveal **One Shots**, then use an empty cell's **Import One Shot** action, drop a local audio file into it, or use **Add to One Shots** from a playlist cue's Basic Info. Adding an existing cue creates an independent copy with a new identity. Later edits to the One Shot do not change the playlist source, and later playlist edits do not automatically update the One Shot.

Open a tile's settings and review these choices before assigning its control key:

Setting	Operator decision
Playback: Overlay	Mix with the program without ducking it.
Playback: Duck Program	Temporarily set other active cues to the absolute Program Level, then restore their prior gains. A quieter cue can be raised; rehearse the actual result.
Playback: Replace Program	Stop the other program cues when firing this One Shot.
When triggered again: Restart	A later accepted trigger starts the One Shot again.
When triggered again: Ignore	Ignore further triggers while it is already active.
Ending: Stop / Loop	Finish once or repeat; prepare a stop plan for every loop.
Auto-disarm after fire	Require a new arm after a successful fire; enabled by default.
Output	Use the project default or a deliberately selected separate device.

New One Shots start with Ending Stop, retrigger Restart, and Duck Program behavior at approximately –20 dB program level. Check imported or copied settings rather than assuming every cell matches that initial configuration. **Duck Time** and **Release Time** are displayed but are not consumed by the current engine. Do not depend on them for a precisely timed envelope; rehearse the actual attack and recovery.

Arm, fire, and stop

In **Show Mode**, use **Arm** and verify **ARMED** before firing a tile, its keyboard shortcut, or its MIDI mapping. Unarmed activation is ignored. A successful fire auto-disarms when that setting is enabled; a failed fire does not. The Stop control remains available regardless of arming.

Edit Mode is not arm-protected. Its Play control can fire a One Shot without arming. Leaving Show Mode disarms every cell, so check the bank again after returning to Show Mode. Collapsing the bank is not an emergency stop, and hiding it does not make assigned keys safe to press.

The bank can **Detach** into a separate window and **Attach** again. Rehearse focus and screen placement on the actual machine. Removing a cell's One Shot designation does not delete its source media. Do not treat a hidden, detached, or removed tile as proof that audio has stopped; check active playback.

Assign and verify keyboard shortcuts

Open **Shortcuts -> Customize Shortcuts...** and use the **Keyboard** tab. Select a playback action or configured One Shot and press the desired key. The app reports reserved combinations or conflicts; resolve those deliberately rather than creating ambiguous show controls. Individual tile settings also provide **Keyboard Shortcut**, **Assign shortcut**, and **Clear shortcut**.

Playback assignments belong to the project. No One Shot has a default key. The baseline defaults are Space for Play Next, P for Pause/Resume, Escape for Stop All, Up/Down for selection, and Enter

for Play Selected. Toggle Loop, Cue to Continue, and Jump Cue are initially unbound. F1 is a separate Play Selected audio action, not a help key in this app.

Text fields normally own typing, so a playback letter does not fire while you are editing a name. Close editors and dialogs before the next cue call. Keyboard/MIDI Pause/Resume and Toggle Loop target the first active cue, otherwise the selected audio cue; use the specific cue's visible control if several cues are active and you need certainty about the target.

SAFETY NOTE

SAFETY — Pause/Resume can start audio. With no active cue, keyboard or MIDI Pause/Resume starts the selected audio cue if it is inactive. It is not a universal silence command. Mapped Toggle Loop also edits authored project behavior, subject to Autosave/Save; use Cue to Continue for a runtime-only loop release.

Map a MIDI controller

1. Connect the controller before the show and open the shortcut/control configuration's **MIDI** tab.
2. Select the intended **MIDI Device**. **All Devices** listens broadly; choosing a particular controller reduces accidental input from other connected equipment.
3. Choose **Learn** beside the required action and operate the intended pad, button, or fader once.
4. Check the captured channel and message, resolve any **Reassign** conflict, and leave Learn mode.
5. In a safe rehearsal, test exactly one intended action, including arming and retrigger policy for One Shots.
6. Repeat on the backup computer. MIDI mappings are machine settings, not part of the project document.

There are no default MIDI mappings. Supported inputs include Note, CC, and Pitchbend. A Note On must have nonzero velocity; discrete CC/Pitchbend activation uses values above the midpoint. Note Off does not stop a cue. Do not assume a held pad means “play while held.”

Master Volume uses directional steps, not an absolute fader position. The first received value establishes a reference; subsequent movement nudges the level up or down by the configured multiplier. Use a conservative multiplier and rehearse the full controller travel. Controls are ignored while disconnected, although Learn can still capture a mapping.

External triggering

Cue Basic Info displays **API Trigger URL · POST** with a copy control. An external controller must send the indicated method and authenticate; simply opening the URL in a browser is not equivalent. Have the system administrator configure and test the integration before the show. This source supports authenticated HTTP/WebSocket control, not a built-in OSC listener. Do not create an OSC show plan based on a future-feature description.

9. Video Output

Choose the picture computer and display

Video Output belongs to the desktop client, not to the headless engine. The recommended arrangement keeps the audio engine and video-rendering desktop on the same machine. If you use a remote engine, the picture still appears on the desktop client's display/HDMI and the media is streamed over the network; include that network in rehearsal and failure planning.

Use **Video Output** in the toolbar or **Settings -> Video Output**. Assign the intended display and verify its identity against the physical projector, switcher, or monitor. The app remembers the display assignment on that computer, but the output window starts closed on every application launch. Open and check it for each session.

With only one display or no dedicated assignment, the app uses a normal preview window rather than automatically taking over the control screen fullscreen. Do not mistake a preview window for a correctly assigned projector output. Use an extended desktop, not operating-system display mirroring, when you need separate operator and audience surfaces.

What the audience sees

The output shows one picture at a time. A newer sounding cue takes over the picture; this is a cut, not a layered video mix or a guaranteed dissolve. Video is contained in the output area with letterboxing rather than cropped. The background is opaque black.

When a cue has no usable video, the output can use its **Cue image**, then the configured standby image, then black. Set a Cue image in the cue's Basic Info and configure standby behavior in Video Output settings. Preview/headphone playback does not take over the output. The picture player's audio is muted so that the audio engine remains authoritative.

Use H.264 or HEVC media for this source edition. ProRes and other production codecs are not supported by the documented video path. Container extension alone is not a codec guarantee. Test every video on the exact show machine, including its soundtrack, opening frame, end behavior, aspect ratio, and transitions between audio-only and video cues.

SAFETY NOTE

CAUTION — A fallback can hide a video failure. If video cannot load or decode, the output can fall through to a cue image, standby image, or black without a blocking show alert. A healthy audio cue does not prove the picture is playing. Watch the actual destination during rehearsal.

Fullscreen, keyboard focus, and blackout

Double-click or use the output window's context controls to change fullscreen. If the assigned display disappears, the app closes that output instead of moving it onto the control display; it can reacquire the assignment when the display returns while the session remains enabled. Recheck the physical output after reconnecting a cable.

Eligible playback keys from the focused Video Output are forwarded to the controller. **Escape exits output fullscreen and, with the default shortcut mapping, also invokes Stop All.** If Stop All is remapped, Escape still exits fullscreen. Rehearse this distinction before giving the output window focus during a show.

There is no dedicated video-blackout button or shortcut in this source. **Stop All is not a separate picture-blackout command:** a configured standby image can remain visible after cues stop. If the show needs a guaranteed independent blackout, prepare and rehearse it on the video switcher/projector or another supported part of the venue system. Closing Video Output can expose the desktop and is not an audience-safe blackout procedure.

10. Connect to a remote audio server

Prepare the server deliberately

Use remote mode when the audio computer is separate from the operator's controller. The server computer needs the media, storage, and sound devices. The operator needs its address, control port, access token, and the name of the person authorized to restart it.

For a trusted-LAN setup, an administrator can start the installed standalone server with:

TEXT

```
dwcue-server --bind 0.0.0.0
```

This exposes the control service on the machine's network interfaces. It is not the default local-only configuration. Every bind, including loopback, requires a token in this source. If

LIVEPLAYACCESSTOKEN is unset or empty, the standalone server generates a token and displays it once at startup. A supplied token must contain at least 16 characters; a shorter nonempty value prevents the server from starting. Keep that token private; do not put it in screenshots, public logs, tickets, or this manual.

Default port	Purpose
TCP 4480	Project/control requests, WebSocket transport/state, and media delivery.
UDP 4481	Best-effort LAN discovery; a server can still be reached by address when discovery is unavailable.

Have the administrator allow only the intended trusted-network access. The app does not open firewall rules for you. Plain HTTP/WebSocket control is not a public-internet security boundary; a bearer token is not transport encryption. Do not forward these ports to the internet. Use an administrator-approved secure network arrangement if crossing untrusted networks.

Connect the controller

1. On the welcome screen choose **Change** if already in local mode, then reveal **Connect to a server on the network...** when the remote controls are hidden.
2. Choose **Remote**. Select a discovered server or enter the **Server Address** supplied by the administrator.
3. Enter its **Access token**, then choose **Connect**.
4. Confirm the server identity and project name. A server with a project already open can bring you into that existing session.
5. Check audio readiness and the physical output before firing a cue. A successful health probe alone does not prove that authenticated control is working.

Discovery may be unavailable across subnets, VPNs, or restricted Wi-Fi. Use the explicit address instead of treating an empty discovery list as proof that the engine is down. If the server is on another computer, localhost/127.0.0.1 refers to the controller itself and is the wrong address for that remote machine.

Credentials and shared control

The managed local desktop connection supplies its own session credential automatically. You should not need to copy the local token into a browser, paste it into the show document, or disable authentication. After a managed restart the app refreshes its connection credentials. An external integration must also use the current token.

If a browser-based integration reports an origin rejection, its exact origin must be authorized by the administrator; another localhost spelling or port is not implicitly trusted. Do not work around this by making a broad origin exception during a show.

A remote server is shared state, not a private copy per controller. Another operator can close, replace, or edit its project. Agree who owns show control, project changes, and restart decisions. Dirty local edits trigger an explicit recovery choice rather than being silently replaced; chapter 11 explains the consequences of each choice.

11. Save, back up, recover, and quit

Know what is saved

Autosave is on by default. Turning it off is not an audio safety lock: edits can still affect the active engine document, while the disk file remains unchanged until an explicit save. Watch **Unsaved Changes** and use **File -> Save Project** when you want a durable checkpoint. New and converted shows save to their canonical `.dwcue` path.

Toggling Autosave either on or off force-saves immediately. If your intention is to experiment without writing a change, decide that before changing the toggle and work on a separate copy. A failed save must be resolved; do not assume the absence of a modal means the disk file was updated.

Saving is serialized and the newest pending edits remain dirty until their save succeeds. A late response from an older project or older edit cannot legitimately clear the current unsaved state. Closing a project clears its identity and destination path; a blank welcome screen is not an invitation to overwrite the previous show. A converted legacy show never uses the selected `.liveplay` source as its save target.

The server makes background copies of the existing disk project every 10 minutes into a **backups** folder beside it, retaining at most 20. Those are project-file backups, not full media packages, and they cannot capture unsaved edits that never reached disk. Keep a separate known-good full-show copy as well.

Export a portable show

1. Stop the rehearsal at a known point and save the intended project changes.
2. Use **File -> Export Project....** Export performs a forced save before packaging; resolve any save failure rather than continuing with an assumed current archive.
3. Choose the destination. With a remote server, **Save on Server** writes there and **Download Here** brings the archive to the controller.
4. Keep the resulting `.dwcuepack` archive with its version/date clearly identified.
5. Import it into a separate rehearsal location and verify cues, media readiness, images, and playback with the original source paths unavailable.

SAFETY NOTE

CAUTION — Export packages the project folder. Keep the show in a dedicated folder. Do not choose a folder containing credentials, unrelated documents, personal media, or application data and assume export will include only the files shown in the playlist. Externally linked media also needs a deliberate portability check.

Device assignments, physical patching, local MIDI mappings, and video display identity need checking on the destination machine. A successful archive extraction is not a substitute for that check.

Import a show or archive and inspect repairs

Use **File -> Import Project...** for a portable `.dwcuepack`, an older `.liveplay` show, or an older `.lpa` archive. A direct `.liveplay` import creates an available `.dwcue` sibling beside the source and loads that canonical result. It does not overwrite the legacy document.

For an archive, the app infers native or legacy handling from the `.dwcuepack` or `.lpa` filename. In remote operation, choose **Browse Server** for a server-resident archive or **From This Computer** to upload it, then select a fresh extraction directory on the audio-server computer. A successful import

returns and opens one canonical `.dwcue`. A legacy archive's original bytes remain unchanged and its staged `.liveplay` is not published in the destination.

Extraction refuses unsafe entries and destination collisions rather than silently overwriting an existing show. If import reports a collision, choose a clean destination; do not delete the working show just to force an import. Wait for import and audio readiness, then listen to representative cues and inspect the important transitions.

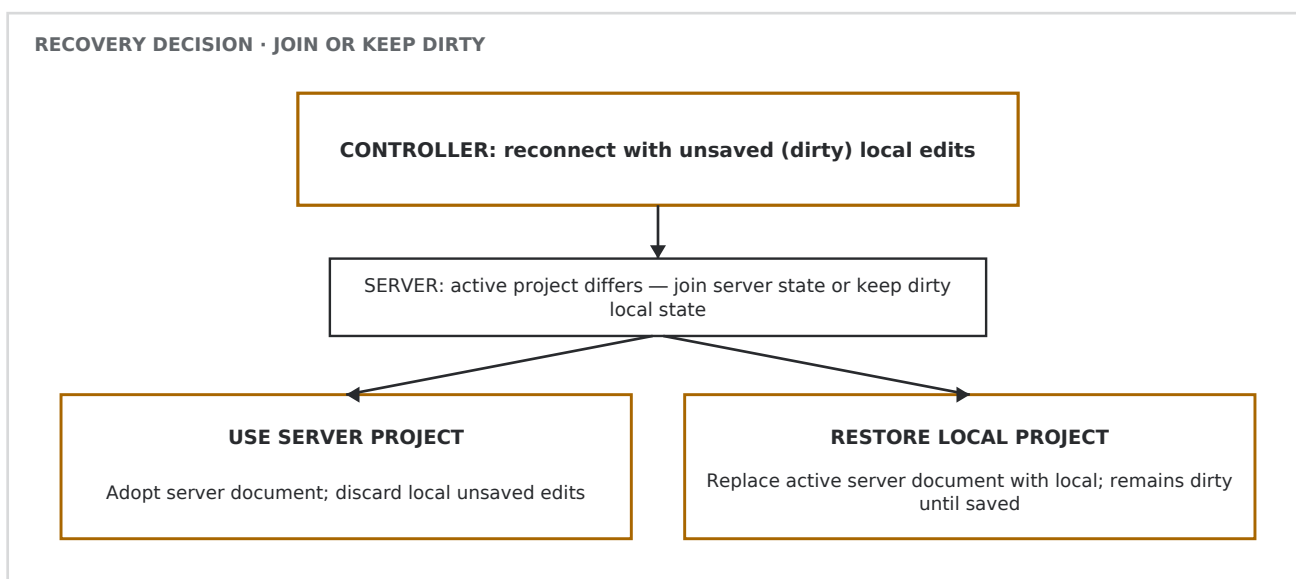
On loading a document that needs supported structural repairs, **Corrupt Project Detected** can appear. **Repair & Save** writes the repaired canonical document. **Open Without Saving** opens the already repaired in-memory document but leaves its canonical disk file unchanged until a later save. It does not recover missing media or guarantee that every damaged project is repairable. Legacy source bytes remain untouched by either choice. Preserve the source, then inspect the cue count, groups, One Shots, and jump targets.

Connection loss is not proof that sound stopped

The **Connection lost** overlay blocks normal playback/edit input while reconnection is attempted. **Retry now** retries the same server. Its **Restart** action relaunches the client only; the audio engine can continue running. **Exit** closes the client. Correct a wrong address or credential through Server Settings rather than repeatedly retrying the wrong destination.

When a network controller loses contact, do not assume the audience has silence. The remote engine may still be playing. Use the venue's agreed communication and independent output-control procedure. Avoid restarting an engine that another operator is actively using.

Choose the correct recovery direction



Prompt / choice	What you are authorizing
Server restarted -> Continue session	Reload the previous project and restore available local in-memory edits. Restored unsaved edits remain dirty; this is not a disk save.
Server restarted -> Start fresh	Immediately discard the client-held document and return to Welcome, without an unsaved-changes prompt. If edits matter, choose Continue session first, then save or export them before leaving the session.
Server project changed -> Use server project	Adopt the server document and discard local unsaved edits.
Server project changed -> Restore local project	Replace the server's active document with the local document. This affects the shared session and remains unsaved until you save it.

A matching path does not prove that two documents have the same edits. The current source asks for a decision when local edits are dirty and a server project is present, including changes to the same path. A clean controller follows the server's authoritative project without needing this conflict decision.

Before **Restore local project**, coordinate with the operator controlling the server. Before **Use server project**, decide whether you need to preserve the local edits. Neither button is a merge tool. After either recovery path, verify cue readiness, output devices, arming, active playback, and the actual saved state before the next GO.

Engine crash recovery is best-effort

A fatal engine crash can trigger an automatic restart after about 5 seconds. Its roughly 2-second recovery heartbeat records the project and at most one playing/fading-in cue with a position. It is not an exact reconstruction of a live mix: paused cues, multiple simultaneous cues, and runtime Cue to Continue are not preserved as a complete scene.

Expect a possible position rollback and recheck the result before taking control. Playback may resume from recovery state, so coordinate the console response instead of assuming a crashed engine will remain silent. Repeated failures eventually disable automatic restart after five consecutive crashes. Preserve logs and diagnose the fault rather than repeatedly relaunching during a show.

Quit the intended part of the system

For unsaved edits, ordinary New/Open/Close actions offer **Save**, **Don't Save**, or **Cancel**. Quit uses **Return to Project**, **Close and disregard changes**, or **Save project, then close**. A failed save cancels the requested close action.

If the managed local engine is running, the next choice distinguishes **Close Client Only** from **Close Server**. **Close Client Only leaves the engine and playback running**. **Close Server stops playback and disconnects every connected client**. Closing a controller connected to a remote engine does not shut down that remote engine.

At pack-down, explicitly stop live cues and previews, verify the physical outputs, save the intended changes, and select the appropriate shutdown action. Closing a window is not the same operation as stopping the show.

12. Troubleshooting at the operator position

Use a short, ordered diagnosis

First protect the audience using the rehearsed stop/mute procedure. Then identify whether the failure is connection, transport, media, output, or picture. Change one thing at a time and record the result. Avoid repeated GO or Restart commands while the actual playback state is unknown.

Symptom	Check in this order
GO does nothing; target stays armed	Connection status, media readiness/errors, correct target, then one deliberate retry. An armed target is preserved after a rejected start.
Cue time moves but there is no sound	Media contains sound; In/Out and cue level; device override; Main device and level; physical console patch, mute, and loudspeaker path. In remote mode check the engine computer's device.
A sting stops the bed	Check Playback Replace Program or cue Ducking Stop All Other Cues. Use Overlay/No Ducking or a rehearsed Duck Program setting when the bed must continue.
Preview is heard in the house	Stop Preview and verify the actual Preview Device and physical patch. Sharing Main's physical output is not private monitoring.
A loop never advances	Check the saved Loop setting and whether Cue to Continue was armed for this playback instance. A stop/replay cancels the previous continuation.
A group does not leave its last cue	Play Next stays in the same immediate group. Put Go to Item/Index on the final child; group End Behavior is not implemented.
One Shot does not fire	Show Mode arming, current keyboard/MIDI mapping, retrigger Ignore, connection, and media readiness. Note Off is not a stop command.
MIDI volume jumps unexpectedly	Check the directional-step multiplier and controller message stream. The mapping is not an absolute fader position.
Video is black or shows a still image	Confirm Video Output is open, the correct display is assigned, the cue has supported video, and the actual decoder is playing. Fallback images can hide a media failure.
The server appears in discovery but will not connect	UDP discovery does not prove TCP reachability or authentication. Verify address, control port, firewall, and current token.
Changes are missing after a restart	Check which copy was opened, whether the last save succeeded, Autosave state, and available disk backups. Unsaved edits are not in a disk-only backup.
A moved show reports missing media	Restore the whole project folder, check external linked paths and mounted volumes, or replace the missing file in cue Properties and recheck its trims.

Level Check is audible program playback

Level Check is a soundcheck tool, not a silent analysis report or headphone preview. It chooses an approximately 5-second window near a cue's loudest available waveform peak and plays it through the normal program transport. Cues with no usable waveform or a fully silent region may be absent from the check.

Entering the mode does not immediately play the first cue. Use its replay/play control, then Previous/Next to move through eligible cues. Previous and Next start playback automatically. While the bar is active, **R** replays, **[** goes to the previous cue, **]** to the next cue, and **Q** exits. These keys do not take over text fields; the normal Space/Stop All pathways remain available.

Perform this only during soundcheck with the console operator ready. Normal cue routing, ducking, and sequencing still matter; it is not an isolated substitute for rehearsing a show. Exit and verify that soundcheck playback has stopped before opening the house.

Collect useful evidence

Record the exact app build/source edition, operating system, engine computer, local/remote mode, device name, cue name, visible state, and the sequence of actions that caused the problem. Include whether the playhead and meters moved and whether sound/picture was checked at the destination.

There is no general packaged Diagnostics window in this source. Use connection status, Server Settings, device selection, and the persistent server logs. **Restart engine** affects actual playback; obtain the show operator's agreement before using it.

For upgrade compatibility, the managed desktop engine intentionally continues to use the legacy-named **LivePlay** data directory; the app does not copy, move, or rename that profile at startup. On macOS, its engine log is normally **~/Library/Application**

Support/LivePlay/logs/dwcue-server.log. Fatal reports are under its **crash-logs** folder. The normal log rotates to **dwcue-server.log.1** at about 10 MiB. Standalone-server state is separate: on macOS it defaults to **~/Library/Application Support/DonWells Cue/server**, on Windows to **%LOCALAPPDATA%\DonWells Cue\server**, and on Linux to **\$XDGSTATEHOME/dwcue** or **~/.local/state/dwcue**.

Provide a minimal reproducible show or media sample only if you have permission to share it. Remove tokens, personal paths, private media, and unrelated application data from reports. A device's logged negotiated sample rate is better evidence than assuming the API's reported requested/default rate is the physical driver's actual rate.

Report actionable issues through the [project issue tracker](#). Preserve the log around the failure before repeated restarts overwrite or rotate useful evidence.

13. Printable show-day checklists

Before doors

- [] Correct app build and correct named show loaded on the performance computer.
- [] Known-good full-show backup exists and has been opened successfully elsewhere.
- [] All required media is ready; missing-file and decoder errors resolved.
- [] Main device, per-cue overrides, console patch, and actual sound checked.
- [] Preview reaches only the intended headphones/monitor path.
- [] If using LTC, its destination is isolated from the audience path; start time, frame rate, and receiver lock tested.
- [] Cue gains, overlap/ducking behavior, limiter, and transitions rehearsed.
- [] Loop continuation, Jump Cue, and the configured Stop All fade rehearsed.
- [] Group exits use explicit, checked targets where needed.
- [] Correct GO target is visible; shortcuts checked against this project.
- [] Required One Shots armed; retrigger and auto-disarm policy checked.
- [] MIDI mappings checked on this machine; unused controllers disconnected or filtered.
- [] Video Output opened, display verified, and first frame/standby/fallback checked.
- [] Independent audio emergency-silence and video-blackout procedures agreed.
- [] Mains power, sleep policy, notifications, cables, and spare media ready.
- [] Network/server ownership, credentials, and recovery decision-maker agreed.
- [] Intended changes saved; no unresolved Unsaved Changes or recovery prompt.

At an interval or operator handover

- [] Active cues and any interval material identified explicitly.
- [] Next called cue and the displayed Play Next target agree.
- [] Armed One Shots and non-default shortcut mappings communicated.
- [] Current Autosave/dirty state and last known-good save identified.
- [] Output, network, or video issues communicated rather than silently worked around.
- [] Incoming operator knows whether closing this client leaves the engine running.

After the show

- [] Live cues and Preview stopped; physical outputs checked.
- [] Video output and standby handled according to the venue's pack-down plan.
- [] Intended edits saved and a dated archive/backup made where required.
- [] Any incident notes and relevant logs preserved without exposing credentials.
- [] Appropriate Close Client Only / Close Server choice made.
- [] Engine shutdown coordinated with every other connected operator.
- [] Hardware disconnected only after the agreed shutdown sequence.

Handover record

Record	Fill in before the performance
Show / revision / date	
App build / source edition	
Engine computer / address	
Main / Preview / LTC devices	
Video display / standby plan	
First GO target / first armed One Shots	
Stop All fade / independent mute procedure	
Save / archive location	
Responsible operator / recovery contact	

Do not write the access token on a publicly visible handover sheet. Store credentials using the venue's approved private method.

14. Quick reference and edition notes

Default controls

These are source defaults, not a promise about a project's customized assignments. Check the actual Shortcut settings. Playback keys normally yield while you type in an input field.

Control	Default action
Space	Play Next / GO
P	Pause/Resume the first active cue; with none active, starts the selected audio if inactive
Escape	Stop All Cues using the configured global fade
Up / Down arrows	Move playlist selection
Enter	Play Selected audio
F1	Separate Play Selected audio action
Toggle Loop	No default binding. If assigned, sets End Behavior to Loop or Nothing: a project edit, not a one-pass release
Cue to Continue / Jump Cue	No default binding; use the appropriate live control or assign deliberately
One Shot keys	No default binding
Cmd/Ctrl+S	Save Project
Cmd/Ctrl+O	Open Project
Cmd/Ctrl+N	New Project
Cmd/Ctrl+W	Close Project
Cmd/Ctrl+Q	Exit / quit workflow
F11	Fullscreen

With Video Output focused, Escape also exits its fullscreen mode. In Level Check, R / [/] / Q have the temporary meanings described in chapter 12. MIDI bindings belong to the machine; keyboard playback assignments belong to the project.

Current-source boundaries

- Group Play First / Play All works, but group End Behavior does not drive the sequencer. A child's Play Next remains in its immediate container.
- The audio Start Behavior dropdown's Play Next / Play Item / Play Index choices are not implemented by the current server path. Use supported End Behavior or Start Next marker workflows.
- One Shot Duck Time and Release Time values do not control runtime envelope timing in this source.
- The advanced routing API exists, but its matrix component is not mounted as an operator-accessible screen.
- There is no built-in OSC listener, dedicated video-blackout command, or general packaged Diagnostics window.
- Video uses one picture at a time. H.264/HEVC capability and display/focus behavior must be checked on the performance hardware; source-level support is not a certification of every computer or codec profile.

- Engine crash recovery is best-effort, not a redundant playback system or complete live-state snapshot.

About this edition

This manual documents the current source with package version **2.6.13**. The screenshots retain their own earlier capture provenance and use generated practice media in an isolated example show; no audience audio, private project data, or credentials are represented.

The preparation and recovery instructions were checked against the Vue/Electron interface and C++ control engine. The screenshots show previously exercised create/import/play/stop/show-mode paths; they are not evidence that a released installer implements this working-tree naming contract. Source verification does not replace rehearsal of conversion, acoustic levels, physical routing, external LTC lock, network performance, Windows focus behavior, or projector/display hot-plug handling.

For technical maintainers, the principal source areas are **client/app/components**, **client/app/composables/useProject.ts**, **useAudioEngine.ts**, **useLiveplayServer.ts**, **useConnectionGuard.ts**, **useLevelCheck.ts**, **client/electron/main.js**, **server/src/core/project_state.cpp**, and **server/src/net/control_server.cpp**. The repository's root, client, and server READMEs are developer references; historical design documents are not operator promises.

The editable manual is **docs/operators-manual.md**. Its PDF is generated by **scripts/generate-operators-manual.py**, with screenshot provenance in **docs/manual-assets/captures.json**. Update the source and regenerate the PDF together after an operator-visible change.

Useful links

- [DonWells Cue project and source](#)
- [Published releases and installer notes](#)
- [Issue tracker](#)
- [Project website](#)

Return to [the operating rules](#), [the GO procedure](#), [recovery decisions](#), or [the printable checklists](#) when using the PDF at the operator position.